



Vulnerable to attack

The NVA targeted American outposts that were vulnerable to siege. Khe Sanh, near the Ho Chi Minh Trail, was massively reinforced and its landing strip upgraded through 1967. This aerial view was taken in November of that year.

The siege of Dak To

A similar situation played out in June 1967 at Dak To firebase in Kontum province, near the Laotian border, not far from the Ho Chi Minh Trail. The siege began with a heavy mortar attack against US Special Forces stationed there. Fighting was so intense that US airborne, infantry, and cavalry units, as well as ARVN forces, were deployed to hold the firebase and surrounding hilltops.

American forces eventually prevailed with a combination of close aerial support and a series of bold sweeps during which they dislodged the NVA from their elevated positions, which were connected by trenches and tunnels. Fighting was especially fierce on Hill 875 as US airborne troops stormed the summit. The firefight took more than two days to play out and included one of the war's worst friendly-fire incidents—42 soldiers killed and as many wounded when a US Air Force fighter dropped a bomb on a US position by mistake.

The siege was finally lifted during a fierce battle through the first three weeks of November, with heavy casualties on both sides. More than 400 American and ARVN troops and at least 1,000 NVA lost their lives in the battle. Three members of the 173rd Airborne Brigade were posthumously awarded the Congressional Medal of Honor for their actions.